

Melchizedek

Codex Reference: IX,1

Translated by: Birger A. Pearson and Søren Giversen

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Birger A. Pearson

Translated by Søren Giversen and Birger A. Pearson

This tractate is the only writing of the Nag Hammadi corpus that features, or even names, the mysterious “priest of God Most High” encountered by the patriarch Abraham, according to Genesis 14:18 (cf. Ps 110:4). Its title is partially preserved on one of the fragments making up page 1 of Codex IX. Unfortunately, this codex is in a rather bad state of preservation. Only 19 lines of text (out of approximately 745) from the tractate *Melchizedek* are completely preserved, and less than 50 percent of the total text is recoverable even by means of conjectural restoration. Thus, since there is no other extant copy of this tractate, only a very imperfect picture of its content is possible to attain, and what has been preserved is susceptible to more than one interpretation. The following account must be read with these caveats in mind.

In terms of literary genre, this tractate is an apocalypse, specifically an “apocalypse of Melchizedek.” It contains revelations putatively given by heavenly intermediaries to Melchizedek, who communicates the revelations to a privileged few. Readers are implicitly invited to see themselves as sharing in these special revelations, as members of these privileged few.

The tractate consists of three main parts:

I. 1,1 (?)–14,5: The tractate apparently opens with a brief vocative address by Melchizedek to Jesus Christ, but there quickly follows a third revelation addressed to Melchizedek by a heavenly informant whose name has been restored as “Gamaliel” (5,18). An important feature of this revelation, addressed to the “priest of God Most High” (12,10–11; cf. Gn 14:18), is a prophecy of the ministry, death, and resurrection of the Savior, Jesus Christ. It also contains a remarkable passage which predicts the coming of (docetic) heretics who will deny the physical reality of Jesus’ incarnation, death, and resurrection (5,1–11). Melchizedek himself plays a role in this revelation, for a future high-priestly office is prophesied for him (esp. 5,11–17). A prophecy of the final triumph over death concludes this first revelation (14,8–9).

II. 14,15–18,11 (?): Melchizedek then arises with joy, and undertakes several ritual actions which may also provide for us some insights into the cultic life of the community for which the writing as a whole is intended: prayers of thanksgiving, baptism, reception of the priestly name, and a presentation of spiritual offerings. This liturgical section also includes a lengthy set of invocations, each beginning “Holy are you,” addressed to members of the heavenly world (16,16–18,7; cf. 5,27–6,10). What is of special interest here is that most of the names of these divine beings are names that appear in such gnostic texts as *The Apocryphon of John* and other tractates asso-

ciated with Sethian Gnosticism. These names include Barbelo, Harmozel, Oroiael, Daveithe, Eleleth, and others.

III. 18,11(?)–27,10: A second set of revelations transports Melchizedek into the future, again centering on the crucifixion and resurrection of Jesus Christ. But this time—if our reconstruction of the fragmentary text is correct—Melchizedek is given to understand that the spiritual triumph of Christ over his enemies will be that of Melchizedek himself!

Our tractate thus presents a number of challenging features of special interest to the historian of religions; it is indeed a melange of traditions of Jewish, Christian, and Gnostic stamp. Its presentation of the figure of Melchizedek is a case in point: he is not only the ancient “priest of God Most High” known to us from the Bible, but he also returns as an eschatological “high-priest” and “holy warrior.” Such Jewish apocalyptic material as the Melchizedek fragments from Qumran (11QMelch) and 2 (Slavonic) Enoch shed considerable light on these features.

In this tractate, Melchizedek’s appearance in the endtime is tied to the career of Jesus Christ: his incarnation, death, and resurrection. In other words, Jesus Christ is Melchizedek! Such an idea can be understood as rooted in an interpretation of Hebrews 7:3. Moreover, the idea that Melchizedek is the “Son of God” (i.e., identical to Jesus Christ) gained currency in some early Christian circles, particularly in Egypt.

Can anything be determined about the religious community for which our tractate was composed? The fourth-century bishop of Salamis in Cyprus, St. Epiphanius, gives us an account of a Christian sect whose members referred to themselves as “Melchizedekians” (*Haer.* 55). A comparison of Epiphanius’ account with *Melchizedek* reveals enough features in common to suggest that the latter may have originated in a group of “Melchizedekians,” features such as the glorification of the priesthood of Melchizedek and a Christology that insisted on the true humanity of Christ. (The Melchizedekians were not Gnostics.)

But what of the gnostic features clearly discernible in the text? These include the divine names from gnostic mythology already mentioned, a fragment of a theogonic myth (9,1–10), a gnostic interpretation of the paradise story (9,28–10,11), and a reference to the “children of Seth” (5,20). One possible explanation of these features is that an earlier form of the text has undergone a process of gnostic editing: the latest redactor was a Gnostic who identified Melchizedek-Christ with the gnostic savior Seth and who interpolated into the text the various gnostic features that are now found in it. The final form of *Melchizedek* is thus a product of Sethian Gnosticism. Other explanations are, of course, possible.

The tractate *Melchizedek* was written originally in Greek, probably in Egypt. A third-century date is likely, though it could be earlier (or later).